



Every Sinner a Saint.

The Observant Message of El Monte Commandery No. 2, KT

18 December, 2022

Sir Knights, Companions, Brethren and Honoured Guests,

Tonight, we come together to observe the miracle of the birth of our Lord and Savior, Christ Jesus. We lift up our hearts in praise of Him who would bring us the Gospel of Love and Compassion. This season we join our voices, no matter how near or far, in joyous song of the arrival of the King of Kings, Immanuel.

For a moment, I'd like to focus on the sinner that became His servant, and the servant who became a Saint. In Latin, the Sanctus (or Saint) simply means Holy, or pious if you will. It is a title bestowed upon those truly devoted - who we consider a friend of God. They are not meant to be worshipped but rather venerated and respected. To do otherwise is to rob them of their humanity and to deny them their flaws.

Saints are sinners who decide to serve God's will in humility. They accept that they are imperfect people made in the image of Perfect Love, called by God to serve His will to the Glory of His Name. It is their love of God and their life of service to God that we are encouraged to emulate.

This Saint I focus on tonight is no different. He was flawed and imperfect. At times was ill-tempered and quick to react. Throughout his life, he would lose control and allow his passions to rule him. Luckily, his mistakes would not define his legacy.

He would be known by many names. The Dutch would call him Sinter Klaas, the Scandinavian Nisse, the Chinese call him the "Nice Old Father" 好老爸 [hǎo lǎo bà] or "Christmas Old Man" 圣诞老人 Shèng dàn Lǎo rén, the French Père Noël; but we know him as Nicholas the Wonderworker.

Saint Nicholas was born on the 15th day of March, Anno Domini 270 in Patara, a city of Lycia on the coast of Asia Minor. He was the only son of wealthy nobles Theophanes and Nona. It's safe to say that Nicholas came from privilege; an environment not known for altruism and charity.

Upon his birth, his parents immediately dedicated their son to God. During his childhood, Nicholas' parents took him to a local teacher, where he studied the classical subjects of the time. Nicholas also received an education in spiritual life from his uncle, the Bishop of Patara. He learned philosophy, as well as scripture and theology from the monks at the New Zion Monastery. Nicholas disciplined himself through fasting and prayer. His love of God was nurtured and his devotion to Christ flourished.

Nicholas was just a teen when his parents died. Nicholas had inherited a vast fortune. Despite his young age, Nicholas had dedicated his life to the service of Christ and pursuing a life in the Church. When the boy grew to manhood, his uncle and namesake ordained Nicholas to be a priest in the Church.

As a priest, Nicholas became active and engaged in the community. Tales of his generosity and benevolence would become the enduring legends of his life. One of the most famous legends tells of a man with three daughters.

This man who had once been wealthy and renowned, had lost his fortune and fallen into poverty. The townspeople had known and respected him when he was rich but now ridiculed and shunned him. They abandoned this man in his hour of need.

He had three beautiful daughters. In those days, without a dowry, his daughters would be faced with a life of poverty, and servitude or far worse. When the family began to run out of food and clothing, the man became desperate; and planned to make money by nefarious means.

Hearing of the father's plight, Nicholas felt sorry for him. Remembering that Christ said, "Truly I tell you, whatever you do to the least of my Brethren, you do to me." – (Matthew 25:40) Nicholas was inspired and decided to help. However, the saint did not want to be seen giving his money to the family, for two reasons. First, in order to be obedient to the words of the Gospel, "Take heed that you do not give your alms before men," – (Matthew 6:1) he planned to give his gift late at night so that his identity would remain a secret. Secondly, Nicholas did not wish to embarrass the father or rob the man of his dignity. The saint thought it was best to obey Christ's words: "Let not your left hand know what your right hand is doing." – (Matthew 6:3)

So he went out, under the cover of night, and threw a large bag of gold into the man's house - through an open window, and fled in the darkness.

Some say the bag landed in the middle of the floor, while others hold that the bag landed in a stocking hung by the fire to dry. Whatever the case, the next morning, the father found the bag, discovered the gold coins, and gave thanks to God, not knowing who had given him the money. He then married off his oldest daughter, using the gold to provide her dowry.

Learning what the father had done, Nicholas prepared another large bag of gold and returned once again late at night to the man's home. He threw the bag into the house through the same window and fled into the darkness. The next morning, the father found the second bag, discovered the gold coins, and fell on his face in thanksgiving to God; then he married off his second daughter. Now, the father was filled with faith and believed that God would provide the money needed to find a husband for his third daughter.

Because he wished to know who was bringing the gold, the father did not sleep that night, but watched in the hope of catching sight of his secret patron. It was not long before the saint returned, walking very quietly, and again cast a bag of money through the window.

The father heard the bag striking the floor and ran as fast as he could in pursuit of the saint. When he caught up with him, he recognized Nicholas. In the darkness of the night, the saint was carrying a pack on his shoulder and almost looked like a peddler himself. But his eyes twinkled, and his cheeks and his nose were red from the cold of the midnight air. There was something about his countenance that brought peace to the man's soul.

Nicholas made the father promise that he would not tell anyone what had happened that night as long as Nicholas remained alive. After speaking to the man at length about things that were profitable to his soul, the saint blessed him, and then vanished into the night. Nicholas saved that family; the father was saved from a life of crime, and the daughters were saved from a terrible future.

This is just one of countless legends that illustrate the life of Saint Nicholas. It would be impossible to tell of every example of his generosity to the poor, or to count the hungry people he fed, the naked he clothed, the people in debt he delivered from their creditors, or the innocent he saved from execution.

We can learn a lot from the example of Saint Nicholas the Wonderworker. Imagine a world where “...whether you eat or drink, or whatever you do...” you “...do everything for the glory of God.” – (1 Corinthians 10:31) Imagine a world where neighbor helped neighbor – no camera, no social media posts, no applause; no recognition, parades, medals, or trophies given, but rather, like the example of Saint Nicholas, Neighbor elevated and truly helped neighbor anonymously, secretly, and with Christ in their hearts.

Saint Nicholas sought to bring his community closer to God. The true miracle of Christmas was the perfect gift that lay in a manger more than 2,000 years ago on that clear silent night. By command, through Christ's sacred words, Nicholas chose to "...deny himself and take up his cross and follow..." – (Matthew 16:24) our Lord and Savior, the Redeemer, Christ Jesus. Nicholas kept the Gospel alive in his actions; loving God with all his heart, soul, and mind; loving his neighbor as himself; [Matthew 22:36-40]; Nicholas kept Christ in his heart daily by his faith and his focus [Ephesians 3:17, Romans 8:10]

And to those who doubt, Yes Virginia there is a Santa Claus; he was a man who dedicated his life to God, to charity, to serving God's will above everything, and to doing the right thing for the right reasons. He was a saint; an imperfect man made in the image of Perfect Love, called by God to serve His will to the Glory of His Name. He was flawed, and did not always do the right thing, but in the memory of his life, his legend and legacy offers each of us an example. For like Saint Nicholas, each of us can keep Christ in our hearts – in this way, Christmas is not just one day of the year; but rather, Christmas can be every day.

The lesson of Saint Nicholas is this:

"Above all, clothe yourselves with love, which binds everything together in perfect harmony. And let the peace of Christ rule in your hearts, to which indeed you were called in the one body. And be thankful. Let the word of Christ dwell in you richly; teach and admonish one another in all wisdom; and with gratitude in your hearts sing psalms, hymns, and spiritual songs to God. And whatever you do, in word or deed, do everything in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks to God the Father through him." – (Colossians 3: 14-17)

Yours in Knightly Courtesy,



Sir Knight William E. McCraw
Eminent Commander
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